

EYEWITNESS June 8, 1972

Napalm Attack

The NVA occupied the village of Trang Bang during the Easter Offensive in 1972. As families fled, South Vietnamese pilots dropped napalm bombs, believing their targets to be enemy soldiers. Photographer Nick Ut captured nine-year-old Phan Thi Kim Phuc screaming “Too hot!” in agony, as she ran naked from her village. Phuc sought asylum in Canada in 1992, and now speaks publicly about what happened.

She describes running from Cao Dai temple in Trang Bang and seeing an airplane getting lower. It dropped four bombs and then there was fire all around. It spread over her body, especially her left arm, burning off her clothes. On Road No.1 from Saigon to Phnom Penh, her photo was taken and then a soldier gave her a drink and poured water over her body. She lost consciousness and woke up in hospital, where she spent 14 months and had 17 operations.

When she eventually went home, she found that their house was destroyed and they had lost everything. They survived from day to day. Despite the pain, itching, and headaches she suffered almost constantly, Phan Thi Kim Phuc dreamed of becoming a doctor. But her studies were cut short by local government who refused to allow her to go to school anymore.

“ They wanted me as a symbol of the state.”

PHAN THI KIM PHUC, FROM *THE LONG ROAD TO FORGIVENESS*, NATIONAL PUBLIC RADIO, JUNE 30, 2008